

Northern Australia is considered one of the ‘frontlines’ from a biosecurity perspective. There have been numerous plant pest/disease detections over the last 10 years in northern Australia, many of them significant in terms of costs (financial and social) to industry, the environment, and the public (through extended/costly responses).

The NAPCaRN has been developed in partnership with the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy (NABS) to build capacity across government, industry and indigenous stakeholders in northern Australia. The network will improve biosecurity leadership and mentoring in the north, enhance partnerships with industry and First Nations people and will provide a recruitment pipeline for biosecurity agencies. The initiative will partner technical experience with mentoring initiatives and internships, while boosting response capability to combat new detections of plant pests and diseases.

The establishment of the NAPCaRN will bolster Indigenous and industry capability through liaison officers based in the north. Nine positions will be established across northern Australia with 3 positions each in Western Australia, the Northern Territory and Queensland, enhancing surveillance, engagement and diagnostic capabilities. This co-ordinated plant biosecurity network will include:

- one technical position each (e.g., entomologist, plant pathologist and/or molecular biologist),
- a biosecurity intern officer position each that will be partnered with the technical positions (same disciplines); and
- a biosecurity liaison officer position (industry and/or indigenous) for each northern jurisdiction.

All positions will be located in the north, directly benefiting local northern economies. These positions will be supported by an extensive program of initiatives including mentoring, biosecurity leadership seminars, technical training and other capacity and capability initiatives.

Based in the Northern Territory, the NAPCaRN Director will work closely with QLD and WA to deliver the program of work, which will significantly uplift biosecurity capacity and capability in the north at a time when exotic pests and diseases (including black sigatoka, exotic fruit flies and citrus canker) have a higher risk of incursion into northern Australia due to factors such as climate change and geopolitical shifts in our near neighbours (Timor Leste, Papua New Guinea and Indonesia).

Promoting diversity and inclusivity in agriculture in northern Australia

The role of NAPCaRN

Traditionally, the north has experienced challenges associated with attracting and retaining skilled and experienced staff. The NAPCaRN initiative aims to address this issue by:

- Empowering and growing our staff by offering training, mentoring and internships.
- Creating and facilitating development of networks, partnerships, collaborations and linkages to help support our staff to grow and develop.
- Offering learning and educational opportunities to enhance knowledge and skills.

- Supporting individuals to grow and develop, identify future pathways and progress through the biosecurity system.
- Aligning people's values with their interests and needs in the north.

NAPCaRN Initiatives

Lunchtime Leadership Series

The 'Lunch with Leaders' series is one of the initiatives under NAPCaRN to motivate, encourage and support current and emerging leaders across northern Australia through stories, challenges, reflections and lessons learned from inspiring and courageous leaders.

The events are virtual so anyone with an internet connection can attend. The first session was held on 4 August with guest speaker Cathy McGowan.

The leadership series is open to anyone. Those interested in attending can email NABS@aff.gov.au. A reminder will be sent each month prior to the upcoming event.

While we will endeavour to maintain the program, please note that it may be subject to change due to circumstances beyond our control.

Download

[Lunch with leaders series program \(PDF 440 KB\)](#) [Lunch with leaders series program \(DOCX 462 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Lunch with Cathy McGowan

Lunch with Paul Burke

Lunch with Beth Woods

Lunch with Mike Guerin

Lunch with Lois Ransom

Lunch with Grassroots Leaders

Lunch with Suzie Hullick

Breakfast with Minister Ah Kit

Lunch with Anthony Wilkes

Breakfast with Peter Wilson

Lunch with Robert McInnes: Part 1

Lunch with Robert McInnes: Part 2

Lunch with Robert McInnes: Part 3

Lunch with Deb Wightman

Mentoring program

The NAPCaRN mentoring program is open to individuals from government, industry and indigenous organisations who are engaged in roles that have some engagement or involvement in biosecurity, leadership, or who are committed to building capacity in northern Australia. The intent is to provide support, growth and learning opportunities for the participants.

There are many benefits that can be realised through mentoring, including:

- Increased self-confidence
- Increased self-awareness and capacity to self-reflect
- Improved communication, listening and questioning skills
- Enhanced networks and connections
- Exposure to new and different perspectives
- Improved goal-setting skills
- The opportunity to learn from someone else's experience
- Increased job satisfaction.

Feedback from other programs has indicated that mentees feel greater confidence in approaching people and opportunities in different ways and with renewed self-belief. Mentors have indicated that these programs provide a rewarding way to share expertise, knowledge and experience and to help others to achieve success. It is also recognised as an opportunity for mentors to learn more about themselves. As such, mentoring leads to greater self-awareness and growth for both parties.

Eligibility

The program is open to individuals of any age, gender, cultural group, background, socio-economic status, job level or ability. Those in regional and remote areas are encouraged to apply. While preference will be given to those in northern locations, applicants from other locations may also be accepted into the program.

The program commences in September each year and concludes in June the following year. During the program, the mentoring pairs will meet a minimum of six times over the 8-month period. It is anticipated that the meetings will be held virtually; however, for those located in the same town/region, there may be opportunities for face-to-face meetings as well.

NAPCaRN Events: Recent and upcoming

Inaugural NAPCaRN Northern Plant Biosecurity Roundtable: 3-4 October 2023

The Biosecurity Roundtable aims to bring together industry, government and Indigenous stakeholders from across northern Australia. The intent is to build knowledge and learning, facilitate partnerships and collaboration across the north, and enhance on-ground biosecurity outcomes through coordinated approaches to biosecurity.

Lunchtime Leadership Series

See [downloadable program](#) for further information.

4 August 2023	Cathy McGowan
25 August 2023	Paul Burke
8 September 2023	Beth Woods
22 September 2023	Mike Guerin
20 October 2023	Senator Susan McDonald
3 November 2023	Lois Ransom
17 November 2023	PANEL: Grassroots Leadership (Indigenous Rangers)
1 December 2023	Suzi Hullick
23 February 2024	Anthony Wilkes

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/australia/northern-australia-biosecurity-strategy-2030/napcarn>